

5 Dramatic Irony Attacks on Tanvir

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Only in India could a playwright of Habib Tanvir's stature face disruptions and boycott of his shows. In October 1982, INDIA TODAY had reported that western contemporary theatre guru Peter Brook had been so impressed by Tanvir's Naya Theatre that he had said "the group represents an absolute extreme of purity". The controversies began in the aftermath of the Babri Masjid demolition in 1992 when the RSS took umbrage to his play *Ponga Pandit* and disrupted several shows. They even incited people to boycott his plays and dubbed Tanvir anti-Hindu. The play had been performed since the 1960s and nobody had found it objectionable till then.

6 Centre of Trouble IGNCA Takeover

The Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA) became an arena for a tug of war when an amendment in its deed in 1995 was challenged in the Delhi High Court, which ordered it to be dissolved. The amendment had made the centre the fiefdom of the Gandhis, with Sonia Gandhi becoming IGNCA's president for life and Kapila Vatsyayan a life trustee. The NDA government retired Vatsyayan after the order. It amounted to nothing when she made a comeback as member of the IGNCA trust 2005.

7 More Than a Ripple Water Controversy



Filmmaker Deepa Mehta had yet another tryst with controversy while making *Water*, a depiction of the plight of Varanasi widows. "An angry mob attacked the film's sets at Tulsi Ghat, destroying property such as carefully created pillars," said INDIA TODAY in February 2000. Mehta went on to shoot the film in Sri Lanka in 2006.



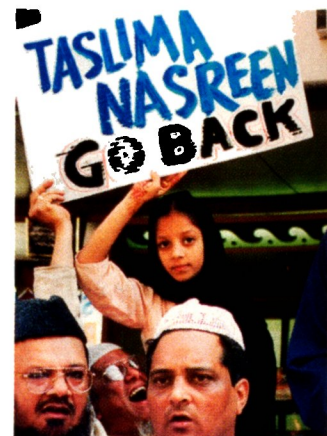
AP PHOTO/MUSTAFA QURAISHI

8 Brush with Violence Husain Forced into Exile

The poster boy of Indian art has been living an exiled life for two years because a group of Indians hasn't been able to understand his artistic philosophy. Maqbool Fida Husain first came under criticism in the 1990s from right-wing groups for his nude paintings of Hindu goddesses. But the clincher came in 2006, when a painting of Bharat Mata saw at least seven cases being filed against him, which forced him to first move to London and then Dubai.

9 Art Assault Baroda Student Outrag

"The self-appointed guardians of public morality" (INDIA TODAY, May 2007) found another victim in an art student at the Maharaja Sayajirao University, Vadodara, Chandra Mohan, when he displayed his works at a university exhibition. The paintings, said to represent Hindu and Christian religious icons in "objectionable" taste, were asked to be removed from the show. Mohan was jailed for a week for "hurting religious sentiments".



10 Writing Her Off Asking Taslima to Leave

Perceived to be a threat to their Muslim vote bank, Taslima Nasreen was booted out of West Bengal by the CPI(M) regime. In December 2007, she had told INDIA TODAY, "I just want to be back". Sadly, it won't be anytime soon.

by Swagata Sen